KEY INDICES

now seem remnants of colonial anthropology—primitive traits, distinctive culture, geographical isolation, shyness of contact with the community at large and backwardness. Despite relying on tropes that fit ill with contemporary understanding, those criteria linger in the formal lexicon because the idea of a 'tribal' marks out not just a sociocultural entity but also a politico-administrative category: it is on these bases that administrative and political concessions are extended to them. Including reservations in education and employment. Indeed, when the Gujjars agitated for tribal status a few years ago, it was denied to them because—after holding up trains for weeks and other modes of public protest—the courts found them lacking in 'shyness of contact'!

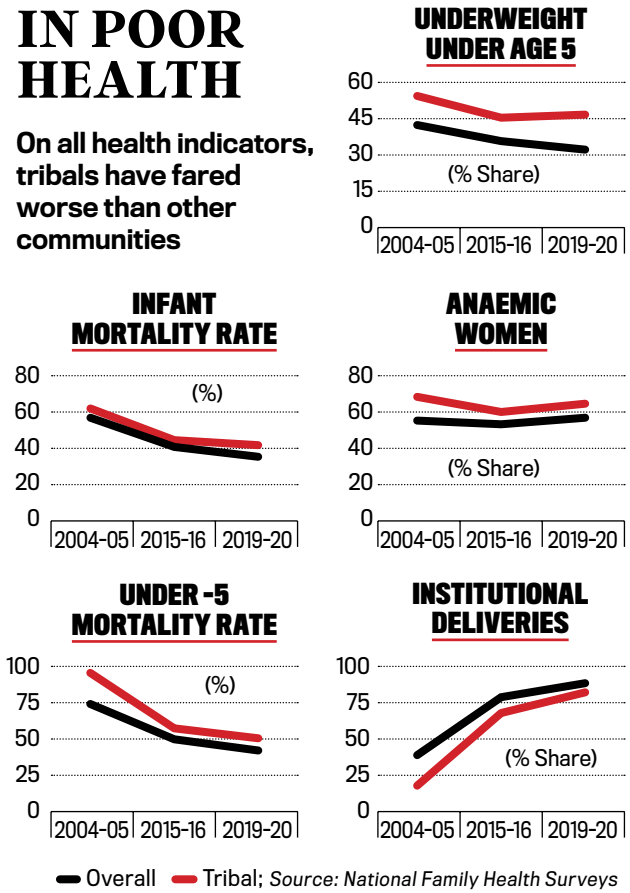
Two distinct administrative arrangements have been made for India's tribal populations in the Constitution in the form of the Fifth and Sixth Schedules, theoretically applicable in places where they are numerically dominant. The Fifth Schedule provides for constitutional safeguards to tribals living in "scheduled areas" in 10 states—Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, MP, Maharashtra, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Rajasthan. The President can declare an area 'scheduled' based on some criteria: high share of tribal population, social and economic backwardness, and the possibility of a compact administrative unit. The discretionary powers of the governor play a critical role in such administration. Generally, this constitutional pledge has mostly been observed in the breach.

The Sixth Schedule covers the administration and control of 10 autonomous tribal regions in Assam, Tripura, Meghalaya and Mizoram. Here, greater powers are devolved to the Autonomous District Councils (ADCs), which have significant legislative, judicial and administrative autonomy. As the Sixth Schedule has been more empowering than the Fifth, several other regions, including parts of Chhattisgarh, Arunachal Pradesh and Ladakh, have been demanding this provision.

The key concern everywhere, of course, is people-oriented development. India has multiple welfare programmes for the socioeconomic uplift of tribals. Around 40 central ministries and departments earmark 4.3 to 17.5 per cent of their total

IN POOR HEALTH

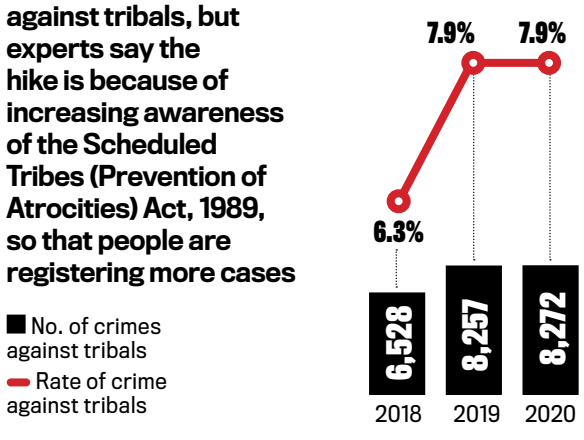
On all health indicators, tribals have fared worse than other communities



CRIMES AGAINST THE TRIBES

There is a rise in the number of crimes against tribals, but experts say the hike is because of increasing awareness of the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, so that people are registering more cases





Source: National Crime Records Bureau reports